



Government Contracting Starter Kit for Small Businesses

Your Complete Roadmap to Winning Government Contracts

Digital Guide — \$39

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1 Why Government Contracting?

The numbers don't lie: The U.S. federal government is the largest buyer of goods and services in the world, spending over \$700 billion per year on contracts. By law, 23% of that — roughly \$160+ billion — is designated for small businesses. Add in state and local government spending, and the total addressable market for small businesses is staggering.

\$700B+

FEDERAL CONTRACTING PER YEAR

23%

MANDATED FOR SMALL BUSINESS

5%

GOAL FOR WOMEN-OWNED BUSINESSES

3%

GOAL FOR HUBZONE BUSINESSES

Why Small Businesses Should Pay Attention

Advantage	Details
Guaranteed Market Share	Federal agencies are legally required to meet small business contracting goals. They MUST buy from you — it's not optional.
Stable Revenue	Government contracts are typically 1-5 years with option years. Once you win, you have predictable, reliable revenue. The government pays its bills.
Reduced Competition	Set-aside contracts limit who can compete. Instead of bidding against Fortune 500 companies, you compete against other small businesses.
Payment Reliability	The government is slow but reliable. The Prompt Payment Act requires agencies to pay within 30 days or pay you interest.
Business Credibility	Federal contracts on your resume open doors with commercial clients, banks, and investors. "We're a government contractor" carries weight.

State & Local Opportunities

Don't overlook state, county, city, and school district contracts. Many are smaller, easier to win, and require less red tape.

Who Can Do Government Contracting?

Almost any legitimate business. The government buys everything from IT services to janitorial supplies, from consulting to construction, from training to transportation. If your business provides a product or service, there's likely a government buyer for it.

Myth Busted: "Government contracting is only for big companies." False. The government is legally mandated to award contracts to small businesses. Many contracts are specifically designed for businesses your size. The barriers to entry are registration and knowledge — not company size.

2

Required Registrations (Step by Step)

Before you can bid on any government contract, you need to complete several registrations. Think of these as getting your "license to play." They're free — never pay anyone to do these for you.

Federal Registrations

1

Get a Login.gov Account

This is the federal government's single sign-on. You'll use it for SAM.gov, certify.sba.gov, and other federal systems. Go to login.gov, create an account with your business email, and set up multi-factor authentication.

2

Register on SAM.gov (System for Award Management)

This is the most critical registration. Without an active SAM.gov registration, you cannot bid on or receive any federal contract.

- Go to sam.gov and log in with Login.gov
- Click "Get Started" under Entity Registration
- You'll need: EIN, legal business name (exact match with IRS), physical address, banking info
- You'll automatically receive a UEI (Unique Entity Identifier) and CAGE code
- Complete all sections: Core Data, Assertions, Reps & Certs, Points of Contact
- Processing time: 7-10 business days
- **Renew annually** — set a calendar reminder 30 days before expiration

3

Register on DSBS (Dynamic Small Business Search)

Go to dsbs.sba.gov and create your business profile. This is the directory contracting officers use to find small businesses. Include your NAICS codes, capabilities, certifications, and a brief business description. Think of this as your dating profile for government buyers.

4

Create a SBA Profile (certify.sba.gov)

If you plan to pursue any SBA certifications (WOSB, 8(a), HUBZone), set up your profile at certify.sba.gov now. Even if you're not ready to certify, getting your profile created saves time later.

Texas State Registrations

5 Register on CMBL (Centralized Master Bidders List)

Texas uses the CMBL to notify vendors about state contract opportunities. Register at comptroller.texas.gov/purchasing/vendor/. Select your commodity codes (Texas uses NIGP codes, not NAICS). This is free and essential for state-level opportunities.

6 Apply for Texas HUB Certification

If you qualify as a Historically Underutilized Business (women-owned, minority-owned, etc.), apply at the Texas Comptroller's office. HUB certification is free and opens doors to state contracts with HUB participation requirements.

7 Register on Local Procurement Portals

Cities and counties have their own vendor registration systems. For example: City of Austin uses Bonfire (austintexas.bonfirehub.com), Travis County has its own purchasing portal, Capital Metro has a procurement page. Register on every local portal in your service area.

Scam Warning: You will receive official-looking letters and emails offering to "complete your SAM registration" or "renew your CAGE code" for \$300-\$1,000+. These are scams. ALL government registrations are FREE. The only official websites are .gov domains.

Registration Tracker

Registration	Status	ID/Number	Expiration Date
Login.gov	☐ Complete		N/A
SAM.gov	☐ Complete	UEI: _____	__/__/__
CAGE Code	☐ Received	_____	N/A
DSBS Profile	☐ Complete		N/A
certify.sba.gov	☐ Complete		N/A
TX CMBL	☐ Complete	VID: _____	__/__/__
TX HUB	☐ Complete		__/__/__
City of Austin (Bonfire)	☐ Complete		__/__/__
Other Local: _____	☐ Complete		__/__/__

3 Understanding NAICS Codes

NAICS codes (North American Industry Classification System) are 6-digit codes that classify what your business does. They're essential because government contracts are assigned NAICS codes, and your SAM.gov profile lists the NAICS codes you can perform under.

How to Choose Your NAICS Codes

1. **Identify your primary service.** What does your business do MOST of the time? This is your primary NAICS code and determines your small business size standard.
2. **Add secondary codes.** Every additional service you can deliver should have a NAICS code. More codes = more opportunities you'll appear in.
3. **Research what agencies buy.** Search SAM.gov for contracts in your field. What NAICS codes do they use? Add those to your profile.

4. **Check size standards.** Each NAICS code has a size standard (annual revenue or employee count). Make sure you qualify as "small" under each code you list.
5. **Use the NAICS search tool.** Go to census.gov/naics and search by keyword to find the right codes.

Common NAICS Codes by Industry

Industry	NAICS Code	Description	Size Standard
General Consulting	541611	Admin & General Management Consulting	\$24.5M
HR Consulting	541612	Human Resources Consulting	\$19M
Training	611430	Professional & Management Development Training	\$15M
IT Services	541512	Computer Systems Design Services	\$34M
Janitorial	561720	Janitorial Services	\$22M
Construction (General)	236220	Commercial & Institutional Building Construction	\$45M
Staffing	561320	Temporary Help Services	\$34M
Marketing	541613	Marketing Consulting Services	\$19M
Landscaping	561730	Landscaping Services	\$9.5M
Security	561612	Security Guards & Patrol Services	\$29M

Important: You can list as many NAICS codes as you want in SAM.gov, but only list services you can actually perform. Misrepresenting your capabilities can result in debarment (being banned from government contracting).

Types of Government Contracts

Understanding the different types of contracts helps you focus your efforts on opportunities where you have the best chance of winning.

By Competition Type

Type	What It Means	Who Can Bid
Full & Open Competition	Any qualified business can bid. No restrictions.	Everyone — small and large businesses compete together
Small Business Set-Aside	Only small businesses (by SBA size standards) can bid	Any small business registered in SAM.gov
WOSB Set-Aside	Only SBA-certified WOSB/EDWOSB businesses can bid	Certified WOSBs in eligible NAICS codes
8(a) Set-Aside	Only SBA 8(a) certified businesses can bid	8(a) participants only
HUBZone Set-Aside	Only HUBZone-certified businesses can bid	HUBZone certified firms
SDVOSB Set-Aside	Only Service-Disabled Veteran-Owned Small Businesses	Certified SDVOSBs
Sole Source	Awarded to one company without competition	Must justify why only one company can do the work. Limits: \$4.5M general, \$7M manufacturing

By Contract Structure

Structure	How It Works	Risk Level
Firm Fixed Price (FFP)	You agree to deliver a specific result for a fixed price. If it costs you more, that's	Higher risk for contractor, but most common for

	your problem. If less, you keep the difference.	services
Time & Materials (T&M)	You bill for hours worked at agreed rates plus materials at cost. More flexible, less risky.	Lower risk for contractor
Cost Reimbursement	Government reimburses your actual costs plus a fee. Requires a compliant accounting system.	Lowest risk but most complex
IDIQ (Indefinite Delivery, Indefinite Quantity)	Framework contract with a minimum and maximum value. Government issues individual task orders as needed.	Winning the IDIQ doesn't guarantee work — you still compete for task orders
BPA (Blanket Purchase Agreement)	Pre-negotiated agreement for recurring purchases. Government can order as needed without a new contract each time.	Great for recurring services
GSA Schedule	Pre-approved government-wide contract vehicle. Once you're on the GSA Schedule, any agency can buy from you.	Long application process but provides broad access

Starting Out? Focus on Firm Fixed Price small business set-asides. They're the most common, easiest to price, and have the least red tape. As you gain experience, you can move into T&M, IDIQ vehicles, and eventually GSA Schedule.

5 Certifications That Give You an Edge

Certifications don't guarantee contracts, but they dramatically expand your opportunities by qualifying you for set-aside contracts with less competition. Think of certifications as lane restrictions on a highway — fewer cars in your lane means less traffic to fight through.

Certification	Who Qualifies	What It Unlocks	Where to Apply
WOSB/EDWOSB Women-Owned Small Business	51%+ woman-owned, woman-controlled	WOSB and EDWOSB set-aside contracts; sole source up to \$4.5M/\$7M	certify.sba.gov
8(a) Business Development	Socially and economically disadvantaged owners; 51%+ owned; in business 2+ years	8(a) set-asides; sole source contracts; mentoring; management/technical assistance	certify.sba.gov
HUBZone	Principal office in a HUBZone; 35%+ employees live in a HUBZone	HUBZone set-asides; 10% price evaluation preference in full & open	certify.sba.gov
SDVOSB Service-Disabled Veteran-Owned	51%+ owned by service-disabled veteran(s)	SDVOSB set-asides; sole source contracts	certify.sba.gov (SBA- verified)
Texas HUB	Minority, women, or disadvantaged business owners in Texas	State of Texas contracts with HUB goals (11- 23%)	comptroller.texas.gov
DBE Disadvantaged Business Enterprise	Socially/economically disadvantaged; PNW under \$1.32M	DOT-funded transportation contracts	State DOT
City WBE/MBE	Woman/minority- owned businesses	City and county contracts with diversity	City purchasing department

Certification Stacking Strategy

The more certifications you hold, the more valuable you are — not just for set-aside contracts, but also as a subcontractor to large prime contractors who need to meet their own small business subcontracting goals.

Example: A business that is WOSB + EDWOSB + 8(a) + HUB + WBE can count toward FIVE different diversity goals simultaneously. For a prime contractor trying to meet their subcontracting plan, hiring you satisfies multiple requirements with one subcontractor. That makes you an extremely attractive partner.

Certification Priority Checklist

- ☐ **SAM.gov registration (required)** — Do this first, it's the foundation for everything
- ☐ **SBA small business self-certification** — Done through SAM.gov Assertions section
- ☐ **WOSB/EDWOSB (if woman-owned)** — Opens significant set-aside opportunities
- ☐ **8(a) (if eligible)** — The most powerful certification for sole source contracts
- ☐ **Texas HUB** — Essential for Texas state contracts
- ☐ **City/local certifications (WBE, MBE, DBE)** — Important for local government work
- ☐ **HUBZone (if eligible)** — Check if your office is in a designated zone at maps.certify.sba.gov

Where to Find Opportunities

Finding the right opportunities is half the battle. Here's where to look, how to set up alerts so opportunities come to you, and how to identify which ones are worth pursuing.

Federal Opportunity Sources

Source	URL	What You'll Find
SAM.gov — Contract Opportunities	sam.gov/search	ALL federal contract opportunities over \$25K. Filter by set-aside type, NAICS code, agency, location. Create saved searches with email alerts.
Agency Procurement Forecasts	Search: "[agency name] procurement forecast"	Advance notice of what agencies plan to buy in the next 6-12 months. Gold mine for preparation.
USASpending.gov	usaspending.gov	Historical data on who won what, for how much. Research your competition and target agencies.
GovWin (Deltek)	govwin.com	Pre-RFP intelligence. Premium service with a free tier. Tracks opportunities from earliest stages.
SubNet (SBA)	subnet.sba.gov	Subcontracting opportunities posted by large prime contractors looking for small business partners.
FPDS (Federal Procurement Data System)	fpds.gov	Detailed contract data. Research existing contracts to prepare for recompetes.

Texas State & Local Sources

Source	URL
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ESBD (Electronic State Business Daily)	esbd.cpa.state.tx.us
Texas SmartBuy (state purchasing)	comptroller.texas.gov/purchasing/
City of Austin (Bonfire)	austintexas.bonfirehub.com
Travis County Purchasing	traviscountytexas.gov/purchasing
Texas Education Agency	tea.texas.gov (for school district contracts)
Capital Metro	capmetro.org/procurement
Austin ISD	austinisd.org/procurement

Setting Up Your Opportunity Pipeline

- ☐ Create SAM.gov saved searches for your top 3-5 NAICS codes with small business set-aside filter
- ☐ Enable daily or weekly email alerts on SAM.gov
- ☐ Register on ESBD and set up email notifications
- ☐ Register on Bonfire and all local procurement portals in your service area
- ☐ Set Google Alerts for "[your industry] government contract" and "[your city] RFP"
- ☐ Check all sources at least 2-3 times per week
- ☐ Create a tracking spreadsheet: Opportunity Name, Agency, NAICS, Due Date, Value, Status, Go/No-Go Decision
- ☐ Contact your local PTAC (Procurement Technical Assistance Center) for free help — find yours at aptac-us.org
- ☐ Attend agency industry days and pre-solicitation conferences
- ☐ Join SBA events and matchmaking sessions

PTAC — Your Secret Weapon: Procurement Technical Assistance Centers are funded by the DoD and provide FREE one-on-one counseling to businesses pursuing government contracts. They help with registration, finding opportunities, proposal writing, and compliance. There is no reason not to use this free resource. Find your local PTAC at aptac-us.org.

7

How to Read and Respond to an RFP

An RFP (Request for Proposal) is the government's formal document asking businesses to submit proposals for a contract. RFPs can be intimidating — they're often 50-200+ pages of dense, technical language. Here's how to break them down.

Key Sections of an RFP

Section	What It Contains	What to Look For
Section A: Solicitation/Contract Form	Cover page with basic info	RFP number, due date/time, contracting officer contact info
Section B: Supplies/Services & Prices	What they're buying and pricing structure	Contract type, CLINs (Contract Line Item Numbers), how to price your proposal
Section C: Statement of Work (SOW) / Performance Work Statement (PWS)	Detailed description of what they need	THIS IS THE MOST IMPORTANT SECTION. Understand exactly what they need, where, when, and the quality standards.
Section L: Instructions to Offerors	How to format and submit your proposal	Page limits, font requirements, volume structure, submission method and deadline. Follow these EXACTLY.
Section M: Evaluation Criteria	How they'll score proposals	What matters most to the evaluator. Weight your proposal accordingly. If "past performance" is weighted 40%, spend 40% of your effort on that section.

Go / No-Go Decision Framework

Not every RFP is worth pursuing. Proposals take significant time and money. Use this framework to decide:

- ☐ **Can we do the work?** Do we have the capabilities, staff, and capacity?
- ☐ **Are we eligible?** Right NAICS code, size standard, certifications, set-aside?

- ☐ **Do we have (or can we get) past performance?**
- ☐ **Can we be competitive on price?** Do we know the price range?
- ☐ **Do we have a relationship with this agency?** Do they know us?
- ☐ **Is the contract profitable?** At what price point does this make money?
- ☐ **Do we have time to write a quality proposal?** Rushing = losing
- ☐ **Is this a recompet?** Who has the contract now? Why might they lose it?

The #1 Rule of RFPs: Follow the instructions in Section L EXACTLY. If they say 12-point Times New Roman, 1-inch margins, and 25-page limit — that's what you do. Proposals get eliminated for formatting violations before the evaluator even reads them. This is not the time to be creative with layout.

Proposal Writing Tips

1. **Mirror their language.** Use the exact terminology from the SOW/PWS in your proposal. If they call it a "deliverable," you call it a "deliverable" — not a "product" or "output."
2. **Address every requirement.** Go through the SOW line by line and make sure your proposal responds to each item. Use a compliance matrix.
3. **Lead with benefits, not features.** Don't just say what you'll do — say what result it will produce for the agency.
4. **Be specific.** "Our experienced team" means nothing. "Our team of 5 certified professionals with an average of 12 years of experience in [specific area]" means something.
5. **Proofread ruthlessly.** Typos and errors signal carelessness. Have someone who didn't write the proposal review it.

Building Your Capability Statement

A Capability Statement (Cap Statement) is a one-page marketing document that summarizes what your business does and why a contracting officer should consider you. It's your business card, resume, and elevator pitch rolled into one page. You'll hand these out at industry days, attach them to emails, and leave them at every meeting.

CAPABILITY STATEMENT TEMPLATE — WHAT TO INCLUDE

Section	Content
Company Header	Logo, company name, tagline (if applicable), contact info
Core Competencies (3-5 bullets)	Your primary services — concise, specific. Example: "Leadership Development & Management Training Programs" not "We provide various training services"
Differentiators (3-4 bullets)	What makes you different from competitors. Certifications, unique expertise, specialized experience, geographic advantage
Past Performance (2-3 examples)	Brief descriptions of relevant contracts or projects. Include client name (if allowed), scope, results, and dollar value
Company Data	UEI, CAGE Code, NAICS codes, DUNS (if still referenced), business size, business type
Certifications	All certifications with logos: WOSB, EDWOSB, 8(a), HUBZone, HUB, WBE, DBE, etc.
Contact Information	Name, title, phone, email, website, physical address

Cap Statement Best Practices

- ☐ **ONE page only** — this is non-negotiable. Contracting officers won't read more than one page
- ☐ Use your brand colors and logo — make it visually professional

- ☐ Use bullet points, not paragraphs — make it scannable in 30 seconds
- ☐ Customize for the audience — tailor core competencies and past performance to match the agency's needs
- ☐ Include all federal identification numbers prominently
- ☐ Print on high-quality paper for in-person events
- ☐ Have a PDF version ready to email instantly
- ☐ Update it quarterly or whenever you win new contracts/certifications
- ☐ Have multiple versions targeted to different agencies or NAICS codes

Customization Wins: A generic cap statement is better than nothing, but a customized one wins meetings. Before attending an industry day or meeting with a contracting officer, research what that agency buys and tailor your core competencies and past performance to match. Show them you understand THEIR needs, not just your capabilities.

Building Past Performance When You Have None

The classic catch-22 of government contracting: you need past performance to win contracts, but you need contracts to get past performance. Here's how to break the cycle.

Strategies to Build Past Performance

Strategy	How It Works	Why It's Effective
1. Subcontracting	Partner with a prime contractor on an existing government contract. You do part of the work and build a past performance record.	Lower risk. You learn the process, build relationships, and create a track record.
2. Commercial Past Performance	Use your private sector work as "relevant experience." Many RFPs accept commercial past performance, especially for small business set-asides.	You probably already have this. Frame commercial work in government-relevant terms.
3. Micro-Purchases	Federal purchases under \$10,000 don't require formal competition. Government purchase card holders can buy from any vendor. Get on their radar.	Quick, easy wins. Each one builds your track record. They add up.
4. State & Local Contracts	State, county, city, and school district contracts are often smaller, easier to win, and count as relevant experience.	Less competition, simpler proposals, faster awards. Great training ground.
5. GSA Advantage/FedMall	If you sell products, list them on government marketplace platforms where agencies shop online.	Agencies buy everyday items through these platforms. Low barrier to entry.
6. Volunteer or Pro Bono Work	Provide services to government agencies or nonprofits at low or no cost to build references and demonstrated capability.	Shows capability and commitment. Great for building relationships.

7. Joint Ventures / Mentor-Protege

Partner with an experienced contractor through a formal joint venture or mentor-protege arrangement. Their past performance can be attributed to the JV.

SBA Mentor-Protege program is specifically designed to help new contractors build capability.

How to Present Past Performance You DO Have

- ☐ Frame every project using the STAR method: **Situation, Task, Action, Result**
- ☐ Quantify results wherever possible: "Trained 200+ employees" / "Reduced turnover by 30%" / "Delivered on time and under budget"
- ☐ Get written references from every satisfied client — don't wait until you need them
- ☐ Create a Past Performance file with project summaries, client contact info, and reference letters
- ☐ Use CPARS (Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System) ratings if you have any government contracts — these are gold
- ☐ Include contract numbers, periods of performance, and dollar values for all government work

The "No Past Performance" Exception: For many small business set-aside contracts, the evaluation criteria state that "a lack of past performance will be rated as neutral, not negative." This means having no past performance won't disqualify you — it just won't help you. Make your technical approach and price so strong that the evaluator wants to give you a chance.

Subcontracting as a Strategy

If you're new to government contracting, subcontracting is one of the smartest first moves you can make. You learn the process, build relationships, gain past performance, and earn revenue — all while someone else deals with the prime contract administration.

Why Prime Contractors Need You

Large companies that win federal contracts over \$750,000 are required to have a **Small Business Subcontracting Plan**. They must set goals for how much work they'll subcontract to small businesses, including specific goals for WOSB, SDVOSB, HUBZone, and 8(a) businesses. If they don't meet these goals, they can lose future contracts.

Translation: Big companies are actively looking for small, certified businesses to subcontract with. They NEED you to win and keep their own contracts. This is not charity — it's business necessity.

How to Find Subcontracting Opportunities

- ❑ **SBA SubNet** (subnet.sba.gov): Database of subcontracting opportunities posted by prime contractors
- ❑ **SAM.gov Sub-Contracting Directory:** Large contractors list their subcontracting POCs — reach out directly
- ❑ **Industry Days & Matchmaking Events:** SBA, PTAC, and agencies host events where primes meet small businesses
- ❑ **Prime Contractor Websites:** Many large contractors (Booz Allen, Deloitte, SAIC, Leidos, etc.) have "Small Business Liaison" pages
- ❑ **Direct Outreach:** Identify who currently holds contracts in your NAICS codes (via FPDS or USASpending) and contact their small business office
- ❑ **Chamber of Commerce & Business Associations:** Network with large contractors at events

What Primes Look for in a Subcontractor

Criteria	What to Demonstrate
Relevant capability	Can you actually do the work? Show them.
Certifications	The more certifications, the better. You help them meet multiple goals.
Reliability	Will you deliver on time and at quality? References help.
Capacity	Can you scale if needed? Do you have enough staff?
Professionalism	Professional capability statement, responsive communication, organized documentation.
Insurance & compliance	General liability, professional liability, workers' comp (as applicable).

Subcontracting Checklist

- ☐ Capability statement ready and tailored for prime contractors
- ☐ Registered on SBA SubNet
- ☐ Identified top 10 prime contractors in your NAICS codes
- ☐ Contacted small business liaison offices at target primes
- ☐ Attended at least one matchmaking or industry day event
- ☐ Insurance documentation current and ready to share
- ☐ References from past clients available
- ☐ Pricing/rate card prepared for common service types
- ☐ Teaming agreement template reviewed by attorney

The Subcontractor-to-Prime Pipeline: Many successful government contractors started as subcontractors. You learn the agency's culture, understand their requirements, build relationships with government personnel, and develop past performance. After 2-3 years as a sub, you're positioned to bid as a prime on the next recompete — and you'll know more about the work than outside bidders.

Common Mistakes That Disqualify Bids

Government contracting has strict rules. Mistakes that would be overlooked in commercial business can instantly disqualify your proposal. Here are the most common errors — and how to avoid every one of them.

#	Mistake	Consequence	How to Avoid It
1	Late submission	Automatically rejected. No exceptions. No appeals.	Submit at least 24 hours early. Systems crash, uploads fail, time zones confuse. Build in a buffer.
2	Not following Section L instructions	Proposal may be deemed "non-responsive" and eliminated	Create a compliance checklist from Section L. Check off every requirement before submitting. Have someone else verify.
3	Expired SAM.gov registration	Ineligible for award	Set a calendar reminder 30 days before expiration. Renew immediately. Check SAM.gov status before every submission.
4	Wrong NAICS code	May not qualify as "small" under the solicitation's NAICS code	Check the NAICS code in the solicitation and verify your business qualifies as small under that specific code's size standard.
5	Missing required certifications or representations	Non-responsive proposal	Complete ALL Reps & Certs in SAM.gov. Check solicitation for any additional required certifications.
6	Not answering all evaluation criteria	Low scores. Evaluators can only score what you submit.	Map every evaluation criterion from Section M to your proposal. If they ask for it, answer it — explicitly.

7	Unbalanced or unreasonable pricing	Government can reject proposals that are too low (indicates you don't understand the work) or too high	Research prevailing wages, BLS data, and past contract values. Price to win AND to deliver profitably.
8	Missing signatures or required forms	Automatic rejection	Use the checklist. Sign everything. Include all required forms (SF-33, SF-1449, etc.)
9	Plagiarizing or recycling old proposals	Evaluators notice. It shows you didn't read THIS solicitation carefully.	Start fresh for each proposal. Reference past work for content, but write to THIS solicitation's requirements.
10	Not attending site visits or pre-proposal conferences	Missing critical information that changes the scope or requirements	Attend every pre-proposal event. Amendments are often issued based on questions raised at these events.
11	Ignoring amendments	Amendments may change requirements, due dates, or evaluation criteria. Missing one can disqualify you.	Monitor SAM.gov for amendments after the initial solicitation. Acknowledge all amendments in your proposal as instructed.

The Hardest Lesson: You can write the best proposal in the world, but if you submit it one minute late, it goes in the trash. Government contracting is a game with strict rules. Learn the rules, follow the rules, and compete on the substance of your proposal — not on technicalities.

About the Author

April Lewis, CEO

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April Lewis is an active government contractor and certified small business advocate who has navigated the entire government contracting landscape — from SAM.gov registration to winning contracts. As the CEO of A.S. Business Consulting LLC, she brings first-hand experience to this guide.

April's company holds the following federal and state certifications:

- **Federal:** UEI EFRHNQ78Z228 | CAGE Code 0JQA8 | SBA WOSB & EDWOSB Certified | EIN 92-1478590
- **Texas:** HUB Certified | CMBL VID 1921478590900
- **City of Austin:** HUB, WBE, DBE Certified
- **NAICS Codes:** 611430, 541611, 541612, and additional secondary codes

Beyond government contracting, April specializes in leadership development, workforce consulting, HR consulting, cultural sensitivity and DEI training, executive coaching, workplace safety (OSHA Certified), emergency management (FEMA Certified), and multi-faceted business consulting.

Education: AA in Business, AA in Criminal Justice, AA in Psychology

Certifications: OSHA Certified, FEMA Certified, Google Developer, Licensed Insurance Agent (TX), Notary Public, Loan Signing Agent, Process Server, Licensed Cosmetologist, Ordained Minister

Need More Help?

Whether you need help with SAM.gov registration, capability statement development, RFP response writing, government contracting strategy, or the full WOSB/EDWOSB certification process, A.S. Business Consulting LLC offers consulting packages designed for small businesses entering the government market.

Services include: Government contracting readiness assessment, SAM.gov registration assistance, capability statement development, RFP/RFQ response support, certification application assistance, and government contracting strategy consulting.

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